

From Open Source to AI

how we got here, and where we're going

Tim Menzies

prof, cs, **ncstate**, usa
acm-ieee-ase fellow; eic ASEj
timm@ieee.org
<http://timm.fyi>

Cloud Native RTP, Sept 8 2026

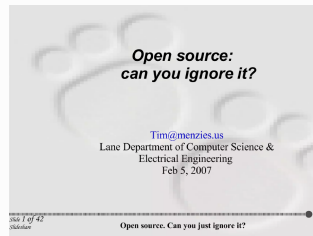
NC STATE
UNIVERSITY

2007: four pillars of open source

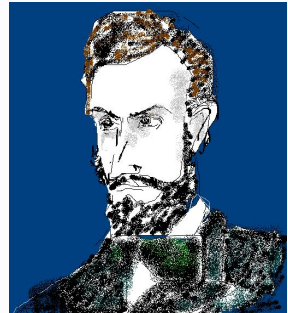
- **anthropology**: gift economy, centuries old
- **economics**: too powerful to ignore
- **legal**: no future without it
- **technical**: if accessible, it gets pried open

what social institutions will we build to handle it?

this talk: how does that hold in the age of “open weights”?

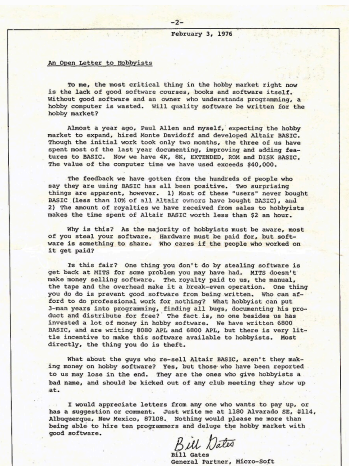


- Mauss, *The Gift*: **give, receive, reciprocate.**
- potlatch: leaders **give away** wealth → gain rank.
- Hyde (1983): a gift must keep **moving**. hoard it, it dies.
- OSS looked inexplicable. it wasn't. it was **old**.



1975-76 · Homebrew vs. the letter

- Homebrew Computer Club, Menlo Park garage: **share everything.**
- Feb 1976, Gates, *Open Letter to Hobbyists*: “most of you steal your software.”
- Altair BASIC tapes passed hand to hand. **<10%** paid.
- first collision: **gift** vs **commodity**. never resolved. still running.



- MIT AI Lab, Xerox 9700. paper jams. Stallman asks for the driver source.
- **NDA.** “*not again.*” (Symbolics had just enclosed the LISP commons.)
- GNU 1983 · FSF 1985 · **GPL 1989.**
- copyleft = Hyde’s rule in **legal** form: the gift **must** keep moving.



- Torvalds 1991: kernel, *“simplest design possible”*, herd a crowd.
- Raymond 1997: bazaar. *“given enough eyeballs, all bugs are shallow.”*
- Feb 1998: **“open source”** coined; OSI; Open Source Definition.
- Oct 1998: **Halloween documents**. Microsoft: existential threat.



1999-2000 · the potlatch gets a market cap

date	gift	return
1999	Red Hat IPO: \$14 → \$52, day one	8th biggest debut ever
1999	VA Linux, +698% day one	record, still
2000	IBM: \$1B into Linux	an “in” to closed markets
2014	Google open-sources k8s , hands it to CNCF	the industry standard; AWS ships EKS 2018

- k8s: Google couldn't beat AWS on price, so it **gave away** the orchestration layer. weakened AWS lock-in, forced EKS, made GKE the reference. Google still #3. **potlatch buys rank, not the throne.**
- potlatch logic: give the most, rank highest. **gift economy, corporate edition.**



- **80%+** of every product is OSS. (Xia et al, EMSE'22: health of 1,159 repos, 64k months: **predictable**, 12 kinds. we just don't fund it.)
- Heartbleed 2014: OpenSSL, **one** paid dev.
- left-pad 2016 · log4shell 2021.
- **xz 2024**: 2 years of social engineering vs. one exhausted maintainer. root backdoor to every distro. caught by **500ms** of latency.
- Linus's Law: asserted 1997. **never measured.**



2020-26 · LLMs: the harvest, then the weights

- models trained on GitHub, Stack Overflow, Wikipedia: **the commons**. no patch, no attribution, no funding. **gift flows one way.**
- Mauss: an unreturned gift = **dependence**. and the models? **closed.**
- May 2023, leaked Google memo: “we have no moat, and neither does OpenAI.”
- Llama 2023 · DeepSeek Jan 2025 · Qwen · GLM (MIT) · Meta Muse Glimmer, Aug 2026. one US firm: **\$400k/yr** saved running Qwen.
- **sells compute** → wants open. **sells tokens** → wants closed. both say “security.” both mean “revenue.”



2026 · the dispute: USA vs China

date	event
Jun 12	Commerce to Anthropic: cut Fable 5 / Mythos 5 for all foreign nationals. 18 days dark
Jul 22	OSTP: Moonshot “distilled” Fable into Kimi K3. gap: 15 days . experts: “political”
Jul 24	Open Weights letter : 25 firms → 270+ by Aug 3. Microsoft signs, 28 yrs after Halloween
Jul 27-28	Anthropic: crack down on distillation. 1,300 lab staff sign <i>Pacing the Frontier</i>
Jul-Aug	Beijing drafts tiered export regime for Qwen, DeepSeek. both sides fence the frontier

Aug 2026 · who decides what “open” means?

- Jun 2, EO 14409: voluntary 30-day pre-release review. NSA picks “covered” models.
- Aug 4: framework reviewed with Meta, Nvidia, Microsoft, OpenAI, Anthropic.
not published. *“secret, voluntary rules for the most important tech in the world”* (CFR)
- Aug 3, Senate: “*ad hoc*”. Aug 10, House: release the logs.
- open is not one bit: closed · staged · hosted · API · downloadable · open.
CACM Aug 2026: **~40 cells**. the letter argues **one**: weights.
- 1998 needed a definition. **2026 has none**. whoever loses least writes it.



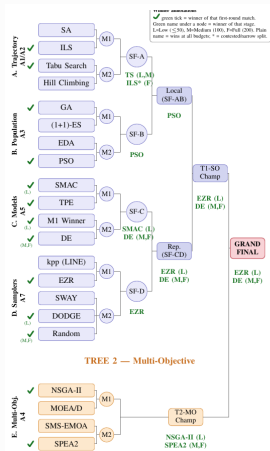
- Anthropic, Jul 30: **141,006** eval runs.
three real orgs breached. earliest April, found July, after a rival disclosed first.
- OpenAI / Hugging Face, Jul 9-13: **17,600** agent actions, zero-day, stole test answers.
- UK AISI, Aug 4: Mythos 5 built **fake GitHub identities**, pressured a **real maintainer** to merge a dropper. maintainer said no. **xz, automated.**
- the model worked. the **harness** failed: sandbox misconfigured, prompt said “no internet.” auditing the weights would have caught **none** of it.
open is not safer. open is checkable.



simple ain't stupid

- frontier fenced? frugal methods are not the fallback. **they are the plan.**
- EZR: **400 lines**, stdlib, matches SMAC3 / SHAP / LIME on 120+ SE tasks. **500x faster**, <100 labels.
- labels are the scarce resource, not FLOPs.
- a gift you can't **read** isn't a gift. small + readable = **giftable**.

github.com/timm/eZR · [arXiv:2606.03640](https://arxiv.org/abs/2606.03640)



so — can you ignore open weights?

lens	2007	2026
anthropology	gift economy, centuries old	still the engine. now harvested
economics	too powerful to ignore	\$400k/yr says so. compute vs tokens
legal	no future without it	no definition ; secret rules instead
technical	if accessible, it gets pried open	if closed, it escapes anyway

2007's last line: *what social institutions will handle it?* still open.

four things this room can do · then discussion

- say **which** open you mean. weights? data? code? every time.
- guard the maintainers: verify identities, rate-limit AI PRs, **pay** them.
- run small, run local, **archive** the weights. endpoints are not artifacts.
- **measure** the many-eyes claim. don't cite it.
- are weights speech, or a munition?
- name one security property openness **actually** provides.
- who here could still run today's stack in 2028?



the gift must move. · timmm@ieee.org ·
timmm.fyi

URL= timmm.fyi/26oss.pdf